

غزل سے آگے – نظم کی دنیا

URDU FOR POETRY LOVERS

VOLUME 5 • BEYOND THE GHAZAL

*Nazm, rubā'ī, qasīda, marsiya, masnavi, geet and free verse
with whole-poem reading, literary movements and anthology practice*

Prepared for

Mahesh Premachandra

From the Perfect Sher to the Developing Poem

Volume 4 trained the eye and ear on the sher: a compact, autonomous chamber of meaning. Volume 5 changes the scale. In a nazm or marsiya, an image may be planted early, transformed in the middle and answered only at the end. Reading therefore becomes an art of memory: you must notice not merely what a line means, but what the poem is doing with time.

Sequence • What becomes possible because this line follows the previous one?

Return • Which image, word or sound comes back—and how has it changed?

Voice • Does the speaker confess, narrate, praise, mourn, argue, remember or summon?

Scale • When does the poem move from person to society, moment to history, or sight to idea?

Ending • Does the close resolve, reverse, widen or deliberately suspend the poem?

The new discipline • Carry earlier lines in memory. A whole poem is not a bag of quotable couplets; its meanings accumulate, echo and revise one another.

The Journey in This Volume

PART I • Forms beyond the ghazal

Nazm, rubā'ī, qasīda, marsiya, masnavi, geet and āzād nazm.

PART II • How a whole poem moves

Voice, scene, argument, image chains, turns and endings.

PART III • History as a listening skill

Delhi and Lucknow, reform, nationalism, progressivism and modernism.

PART IV • Twelve poetry encounters

Script-first excerpts with close reading and whole-poem maps.

PART V • Translation and anthology

Make English bridges without flattening Urdu; build a personal canon.

A simple reading code

S • speaker or voice

I • dominant image

T • turn or transition

E • echo or return

Q • question the poem leaves open

A Gallery of Urdu Poetic Forms

Form is a contract between poet and reader. It creates expectations, but great poems use those expectations flexibly. Learn the listening question attached to each form before collecting technical labels.

Nazm • نظم • A poem organised by a sustained subject, situation, meditation or movement. It may rhyme or not; its unity comes from development.

Read for • Track sequence and transformation rather than expecting every couplet to stand independently.

Rubāʿī • رباعی • A four-line poem with concentrated philosophical, erotic, mystical or satirical force; traditionally associated with a distinctive metrical family.

Read for • Let line four answer, overturn or release the pressure created by the first three.

Qasīda • قصیدہ • A formal ode, often of praise, with room for description, boasting, moral reflection and verbal display.

Read for • Ask how grandeur is manufactured through scale, catalogue, comparison and ceremonial voice.

Marsiya • مرثیہ • An elegiac form; in Urdu its great tradition is inseparable from the remembrance of Karbala, especially in the musaddas stanza.

Read for • Attend to scene, ethical witness, grief, courage and communal memory—not grief alone.

Forms • Narrative, Song and Freedom

Masnavi • سنوی • A long narrative or didactic poem in rhyming couplets, each couplet carrying its own rhyme pair.

Read for • Follow plot, narrator, episode and moral framing; do not isolate every couplet as a miniature ghazal.

Geet • گیت • A song-form drawing strength from refrain, musical repetition, direct emotion and a voice meant to be heard.

Read for • Notice which words are simple because music must carry them—and how repetition changes feeling.

Āzād nazm • آزاد نظم • Free verse that loosens inherited line and rhyme arrangements while retaining deliberate rhythm, image and structure.

Read for • Read line breaks as decisions: where the eye and breath are made to hesitate matters.

Nasrī nazm • نثری نظم • The prose poem: poetic concentration without regular metre or conventional verse lineation.

Read for • Look for image logic, compression, tonal pattern and associative movement rather than rhyme.

Do not confuse • Nazm is not simply 'a poem that is not a ghazal'. It includes many architectures, from tightly rhymed stanzas to free verse and prose poetry.

Choose the Right Reading Posture

FORM	PRIMARY UNIT	MOVEMENT	FIRST QUESTION
Ghazal	sher	constellation	What turns inside this couplet?
Nazm	whole poem	development	What changes from opening to close?
Rubā'ī	four lines	compression	How does line four transform the rest?
Marsiya	scene/stanza	witness	How is ethical memory staged?
Masnavi	episode	narrative	What does the narrator make us expect?
Geet	voice/refrain	musical return	What does repetition intensify?
Free verse	line/image	associative	Why does the line break here?

Transfer skill • The literal-language discipline learned for the sher remains essential. What changes is the size of the memory you must carry.

The Seven-Pass Whole-Poem Method

1 • Encounter • Read aloud without stopping. Record only the emotional weather.

2 • Ground • Resolve essential vocabulary, pronouns and syntax. Write a plain paraphrase by stanza.

3 • Voice • Identify speaker, addressee, situation and degree of reliability.

4 • Map • Name each movement: scene, memory, argument, interruption, vision, return.

5 • Trace • Follow two recurring words or images and note how their value changes.

6 • Hear • Mark sound clusters, refrain, pace, pause and line endings.

7 • Re-enter • Read aloud again. State what the ending makes you reinterpret in the opening.

Resist • Do not begin with biography or historical symbolism. First establish what happens inside the poem itself; context should sharpen evidence, not replace it.

Make a Movement Map

A movement map is a short verb-led outline. It protects you from treating every stanza as a separate quotation and reveals the poem's architecture at a glance.

- Opening** • places a solitary speaker before a silent landscape
- Expansion** • turns the landscape into a memory of collective loss
- Challenge** • questions whether mourning without action is enough
- Vision** • imagines a different moral future
- Return** • revisits the opening image, now charged with responsibility

Write maps with verbs

Prefer: summons, remembers, interrupts, widens, mocks, concedes, blesses, refuses. Avoid vague nouns such as 'sadness' or 'nature'; a map should show action.

One-sentence test • The poem begins by ____, complicates this through ____, and ends by _____. If you cannot fill this accurately, reread before interpreting.

Image Chains: When a Symbol Learns

In a longer poem, an image is not a fixed code. Rain can begin as weather, become remembered childhood, turn into political cleansing and end as an impossible promise. Meaning lies in the sequence of transformations.

First appearance • Describe only what is literally present.

Neighbourhood • Note the verbs, adjectives and objects around the image.

Return • What is repeated exactly, and what has changed?

Ownership • Who sees or names the image now—the same voice or another?

Final charge • What emotional or philosophical work does the last appearance perform?

A four-column image notebook

LOCATION	LITERAL IMAGE	ASSOCIATIONS	CHANGE
Opening	lamp in a room	attention, fragility	first centre
Middle	lamp in wind	danger, persistence	tested
Ending	lamp passed onward	inheritance, community	private light becomes shared

Literary History as a Change in Listening

Periods and movements are not sealed boxes. Use them as hypotheses about what a poem expects from language, society and the poet—not as substitutes for reading.

Dakhani beginnings • Early literary Urdu in the Deccan; regional diction, devotional, romantic and courtly energies.

Listen for • Which words or cadences resist later northern standardisation?

Delhi classical culture • Compression, idiom, metaphysical wit and the mature ghazal tradition.

Listen for • How much pressure can one sher hold?

Lucknow culture • Refinement, performance, rhetorical elaboration and major marsiya traditions.

Listen for • How do ceremony, gesture and scene become verbal art?

Reform and new nazm • Nineteenth-century arguments for moral, social and descriptive poetry; changing ideas of utility and realism.

Listen for • What new public work is poetry asked to perform?

Movements • Twentieth-Century Transformations

National and philosophical poetry • Community, selfhood, freedom, decline and awakening move toward the centre.

Listen for • When does lyric voice become collective address?

Progressive movement • Class, labour, colonialism, gender and justice enter an explicit social-poetic programme.

Listen for • How are inherited symbols repurposed politically?

Modernism and after • Fragmented selfhood, urban alienation, ambiguity, experiment and scepticism toward grand answers.

Listen for • What does difficulty make the reader experience?

Thirty Words for Serious Poetry Reading

Voice

lahja / لہجہ • tone

mukhatib / مخاطب • addressee

raavi / راوی • narrator

khitaab / خطاب • address

nida / ندا • call or cry

Movement

aaghaz / آغاز • beginning

irtiqā / ارتقا • development

mor / موڑ • turn

tasalsul / تسلسل • continuity

ikhtitam / اختتام • ending

Meaning

ma'ni / معنی • meaning

tah / تہ • layer

ishara / اشارہ • suggestion

ramz / رمز • symbol or enigma

siyak-o-sabaq / سیاق و سباق • context

Reading Vocabulary • Continued

Craft

paikar / پیکر • image/form

alamat / علامت • symbol

aahang / آہنگ • rhythmic sonority

takrar / تکرار • repetition

tanaazur / تناظر • perspective

Thought

sha'oor / شعور • consciousness

la-sha'oor / لاشعور • unconscious

tajurba / تجربہ • experience

takhayyul / تخیل • imagination

fikr / فکر • thought/concern

Judgment

taasir / تاثیر • effect

kaifiyat / کیفیت • felt state

pecheedgi / پیچیدگی • complexity

mubham / مبہم • ambiguous

ta'beer / تعبیر • interpretation

Twelve Poetry Encounters

Each encounter begins with the Urdu. Read it twice before using the Roman bridge. The aim is to connect close reading to a larger form, voice or historical pressure.

Notebook rule • For each encounter, write one sentence on language, one on architecture and one question that remains open.

Encounter 01 • Prayer as aspiration

Muhammad Iqbal • Rhymed nazm

لب پہ آتی ہے دعا بن کے تمنا میری
زندگی شمع کی صورت ہو خدایا میری

lab pe aati hai dua ban ke tamanna meri / zindagi sham' ki surat ho khudaya meri

Plain sense • My longing comes to my lips as prayer: O God, may my life be like a candle.

Poetic movement • The private wish becomes an ethical image: a life that spends itself as light.

Language hinge • ban ke—'becoming'—turns desire into utterance; sham' changes life from duration into service.

Whole-poem task • Trace each later image of light, darkness, knowledge and usefulness. Does the poem ask for success, purity, service—or all three?

Encounter 02 • A collective voice wakes

Muhammad Iqbal • Tarana / song-like nazm

سارے جہاں سے اچھا ہندوستان ہمارا

ہم بلبلیں ہیں اس کی یہ گلستاں ہمارا

saare jahan se achchha Hindostan hamara / ham bulbulen hain is ki, yeh gulsitan hamara

Plain sense • Our Hindustan is better than the whole world; we are its nightingales and it is our garden.

Poetic movement • A declarative claim becomes a shared garden image, converting territory into intimate belonging.

Language hinge • hamara repeats possession as fellowship; bulbul and gulsitan adapt classical lyric symbols to collective identity.

Whole-poem task • Mark every first-person plural. What kind of 'we' is built, and who is invited into it?

Encounter 03 • Selfhood and height

Muhammad Iqbal • Philosophical nazm excerpt

خودی کو کر بلند اتنا کہ ہر تقدیر سے پہلے
خدا بندے سے خود پوچھے بتا تیری رضا کیا ہے

khudi ko kar buland itna ke har taqdir se pahle / khuda bande se khud puchhe bata teri raza kya hai

Plain sense • Raise the self so high that before every decree, God asks the servant what they desire.

Poetic movement • Imperative becomes audacious spiritual image: cultivated selfhood alters the relation to fate.

Language hinge • khud / khudi creates lexical resonance; raza can carry desire, consent and willing alignment.

Whole-poem task • Distinguish ego from disciplined selfhood using only the couplet's verbs and relationship.

Encounter 04 • A moral gaze on wealth

Akbar Allahabadi • Satirical sher in a public-critical voice

ہم آہ بھی کرتے ہیں تو ہو جاتے ہیں بدنام
وہ قتل بھی کرتے ہیں تو چرچا نہیں ہوتا

ham aah bhi karte hain to ho jate hain badnam / woh qatl bhi karte hain to charcha nahin hota

Plain sense • If we merely sigh, we are disgraced; even when they kill, it causes no scandal.

Poetic movement • A minor act and a major crime are placed on an unequal social scale.

Language hinge • bhi repeats but distributes consequence unjustly; ham/woh produces the political geometry.

Whole-poem task • Read it as romantic complaint, class satire and critique of power. Which words sustain all three?

Encounter 05 • The country as garden

Brij Narayan Chakbast • Patriotic nazm excerpt

حب وطن سمائے آنکھوں میں نور ہو کر
سر میں ہو اس کا سودا دل میں سرور ہو کر

hubb-e-watan samaye aankhon mein nur ho kar / sar mein ho us ka sauda, dil mein surur ho kar

Plain sense • May love of homeland enter the eyes as light; may it inhabit the head as passion and the heart as joy.

Poetic movement • An abstract allegiance is distributed through body, perception, thought and feeling.

Language hinge • ho kar repeatedly converts love into different embodied states.

Whole-poem task • Draw the body map: eye, head, heart. What does each organ contribute to patriotism?

Encounter 06 • Human dignity

Altaf Husain Hali • Moral nazm excerpt

فرشتے سے بہتر ہے انسان بننا
مگر اس میں لگتی ہے محنت زیادہ

farishte se behtar hai insan banna / magar is mein lagti hai mehnat zyada

Plain sense • To become truly human is better than being an angel—but it requires greater labour.

Poetic movement • An uplifting comparison is checked by magar: dignity is a practice, not a compliment.

Language hinge • banna emphasises becoming; mehnat prevents idealism from floating free of effort.

Whole-poem task • What account of humanity emerges if 'better' depends on struggle rather than innocence?

Encounter 07 • The beloved homeland in exile

Bahadur Shah Zafar • Maqta with elegiac historical resonance

کتنا ہے بد نصیب ظفر دفن کے لیے
دو گز زمین بھی نہ ملی کوئے یار میں

kitna hai bad-nasib Zafar dafn ke liye / do gaz zamin bhi na mili ku-e-yar mein

Plain sense • How unfortunate Zafar is: even for burial, he did not receive two yards of earth in the beloved's land.

Poetic movement • Personal burial space becomes the measure of exile and lost sovereignty.

Language hinge • ku-e-yar can remain beloved's lane while widening toward homeland.

Whole-poem task • Keep romantic and historical readings active together. What is lost if either is erased?

Encounter 08 • Grief becomes witness

Mir Anis • Marsiya tradition excerpt

انسان کو بیدار تو ہو لینے دو
ہر قوم پکارے گی ہمارے ہیں حسین

insan ko bedar to ho lene do / har qaum pukaregi hamare hain Husain

Plain sense • Let humanity awaken; every community will then proclaim that Husain belongs to us.

Poetic movement • Karbala moves from sectarian possession to universal ethical recognition.

Language hinge • insan and har qaum widen the audience; hamare turns belonging into moral adoption.

Whole-poem task • What qualities must the larger poem establish for this universal claim to feel earned?

Encounter 09 • Love and mortality

Mirza Ghalib • Ghazal sher with narrative counterfactual

ہوئے مر کے ہم جو رسوا ہوئے کیوں نہ غرق دریا
نہ کبھی جنازہ اٹھتا نہ کہیں مزار ہوتا

hue mar ke ham jo ruswa, hue kyun na gharq-e-dariya / na kabhi janaza uthta, na kahin mazar hota

Plain sense • Since death brought disgrace, why did I not drown—there would have been no funeral, no grave.

Poetic movement • The speaker imagines erasing even the public traces of death.

Language hinge • na...na constructs an absent ritual world; ruswa makes reputation survive the body.

Whole-poem task • What imagined story lies outside the sher? Write its missing before and after without closing the ambiguity.

Encounter 10 • The simplicity of belonging

Nazeer Akbarabadi • Social-descriptive nazm excerpt

دنیا میں بادشاہ ہے سو ہے وہ بھی آدمی
اور مفلس و گدا ہے سو ہے وہ بھی آدمی

duniya mein badshah hai so hai woh bhi aadmi / aur muflis-o-gada hai so hai woh bhi aadmi

Plain sense • The king in this world is human; the poor beggar too is human.

Poetic movement • Hierarchy is named, then levelled by the identical refrain of humanity.

Language hinge • woh bhi aadmi is plain repetition used as democratic argument.

Whole-poem task • List the social figures the complete poem might catalogue. How does accumulation become thought?

Encounter 11 • Language looks at itself

Mirza Ghalib • Self-reflexive maqta

ہیں اور بھی دنیا میں سخن ور بہت اچھے
کہتے ہیں کہ غالب کا ہے اندازِ بیاں اور

hain aur bhi duniya mein sukhanwar bahut achchhe / kahte hain ke Ghalib ka hai andaz-e-bayan aur

Plain sense • There are many fine poets in the world; they say Ghalib's manner of expression is different.

Poetic movement • Conventional modesty turns into an unmistakable claim of singularity.

Language hinge • aur first means 'other/more'; at the close it means 'different'. The repeated word changes category.

Whole-poem task • Translate both instances of aur differently, then explain what your English loses.

Encounter 12 • Impermanence without abstraction

Mir Taqi Mir • Ghazal sher with cumulative landscape

پتا پتا بوٹا بوٹا حال ہمارا جانے ہے
جانے نہ جانے گل ہی نہ جانے باغ تو سارا جانے ہے

patta patta, buta buta haal hamara jane hai / jane na jane gul hi na jane, bagh to sara jane hai

Plain sense • Every leaf and plant knows my condition; only the flower may not know, though the whole garden does.

Poetic movement • The entire environment becomes witness while the desired centre remains uniquely unknowing.

Language hinge • jane repeats as knowledge, uncertainty and refusal; gul stands apart from bagh.

Whole-poem task • Read the repetitions aloud. Where does musical abundance sharpen emotional exclusion?

Translation as a Bridge, Not a Replacement

A useful translation gets you back to Urdu. It should clarify syntax and situation while admitting where sound, ambiguity, cultural resonance or grammatical openness cannot be carried intact.

Version A • Crib • Stay close to word order and lexical meaning. It may sound awkward; its job is accountability.

Version B • Spoken • Make natural English while preserving who does what to whom.

Version C • Poetic • Recreate pressure, pace or image even when structure changes.

Loss note • Name one thing each version sacrifices: rhyme, ambiguity, register, allusion or intimacy.

کہتے ہیں کہ غالب کا ہے اندازِ بیاں اور

Crib • They say that Ghalib's manner of expression is other.

Spoken • They say Ghalib has a way of speaking all his own.

Loss note • English must choose among other, different, distinctive and another kind; Urdu aur lets the earlier line activate several at once.

Six Translation Traps

Decorating • Do not add 'soul', 'eternal' or 'divine' merely because a line feels elevated.

Flattening address • tu, tum and aap carry relational temperature; note it when English 'you' cannot.

Fixing the beloved • Do not decide gender, biography or mystical identity where Urdu leaves it open.

Killing repetition • Repeated words may be architecture. Varying them for elegant English can destroy the poem.

Explaining inside the line • Keep commentary outside the translation; do not turn poetry into a footnote.

Ignoring register • Persianised grandeur, everyday idiom and deliberately plain diction should not all sound alike.

Best practice • Keep Urdu, Roman bridge, crib, readable translation and interpretive note visibly separate.

Build Your Personal Urdu Anthology

An anthology becomes powerful when it records encounters, not trophies. Choose poems that teach you different forms of attention and revisit them until the Urdu begins to sound before you translate it.

10 shers • Compression, wit and autonomous meaning.

5 complete ghazals • Sound architecture and the emotional range of a shared rhyme system.

5 nazms • Development across a whole poem.

2 marsiya passages • Scene, witness, ethical memory and ceremonial voice.

3 songs or geets • Refrain, musical return and direct emotional diction.

5 modern poems • Line break, image sequence, urban or psychological complexity.

Record for every selection

Urdu text • source and poet • difficult words • one-sentence movement map • dominant image chain • favourite sound • two translations • why it matters now

An Eight-Week Beyond-the-Ghazal Apprenticeship

WEEK	FOCUS	OUTPUT
1	Forms	Identify the contract of eight forms
2	Whole-poem maps	Map three short nazms
3	Voice and address	Compare prayer, satire and lament
4	Image chains	Trace two recurring images
5	History	Read one poem through two contextual lenses
6	Translation	Create crib, spoken and poetic versions
7	Recitation	Record a nazm with deliberate movement
8	Anthology	Curate and introduce ten selections

Weekly rhythm

Day 1 • Listen without text.

Day 2 • Read script-first and resolve language.

Day 3 • Make the movement map.

Day 4 • Trace sound and image.

Day 5 • Read context and one commentary.

Day 6 • Translate and recite.

Day 7 • Write a 150-word personal reading.

The Volume 5 Completion Test

نظم ایک سفر ہے۔ ہر مصرع ایک قدم

A poem is a journey; every line is a step.

Form • Can you explain what kind of attention the poem's form requests?

Grounding • Can you paraphrase each movement without decorating it?

Architecture • Can you show how the ending depends on the opening?

Images • Can you trace one image as it changes rather than assigning it one fixed meaning?

History • Can you use context as evidence rather than as a ready-made answer?

Translation • Can you produce two versions and name their losses?

Voice • Can you recite a complete short nazm with changes of pace and intention?

Ready for Volume 6 when • You can independently select a complete poem, establish its language, map its movements, trace its sound and image chains, place it provisionally in literary history, and present a reading that remains answerable to the Urdu.

A bridge forward

Volume 6 can become a guided anthology: complete classical and modern poems arranged by love, selfhood, exile, devotion, justice, mortality and wonder—with facing vocabulary, commentary and recitation notes.